

Persuasive Speech Outline

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Topic: The regulation of "dopamine-hacking," which is the abuse of biological mechanisms by companies and software engineers alike.

Organizational Pattern: Monroe's Motivated Sequence

Introduction

A. **Attention Getter:** (get your audience interested in your speech):

Testimonies from our fellow classmates highlight how this "brain-hijacking" struggle affects their lives. Our peer, Rosalynd Van Pelt, said this: "When I had difficult papers to write, I lost motivation and used scrolling as a way to forget it. Even if the app had an automated a suggested break, my attention was already low to consider my present moment." Another classmates of our was kind enough to share their own personal impact saying, "While I can't recall a specific instance of this, I know it has happened to me multiple times. It makes me so sad to think that I am not being aware or hospitable to people that I care about when I'm on my phone!"

B. **Relevance:** (state why this topic and information is relevant and valuable to your audience):

I'm guessing you all can relate to the issue at hand as well, and that is what makes this such an important topic! This issue affects the majority of people across the world every single day. The issue has an even greater importance for students, since technology and software are entirely incorporated modern day schooling. Beyond that, being in our twentys, we are all the "target audience" of social media companies, online shopping, and streaming services alike. We can all relate to feeling that "brain fry" after scrolling too long or bingeing Netflix for hours at a time.

C. **Credibility:** (state your interest why you are qualified to talk about this topic):

As a neuroscience major, I have studied the specific pathways and structures involved in the brain's dopamine "reward system" for the last for years. Here are some of the courses relevant to this issue which I have taken in my time as an undergraduate at Baylor University: NSC 3311 (Cognition), NSC 3320 (Learning & Behavior), NSC 3370 (Affective), and NSC 4330 (Advanced Principles). In all four of these courses, we discussed the "reward pathway" which we call the "mesolimbic dopamine pathway" and all the relevant structures. In just a second, I will dive deeper into these "reward" structures and neuro-biological mechanisms behind "dopamine-hijacking."

D. **Thesis:** (state your goal/purpose):

Because technology companies intentionally exploit our neurobiology to keep us hooked, we must recognize that self-control is insufficient, and thus advocate for more neuro-ethical design standards (at the corporate level) and legislative policies (at the governmental level) to restore our cognitive autonomy.

E. **Preview:** (state your plan for the body; *In this speech I am going to...*):

In this speech, I will examine the science of neurobiological exploitation, explain why willpower alone fails, and provide a policy-based solution to reclaim control over our attention.

Transition Sentence: (signal to the audience you are moving from introduction to first main idea)

To begin, we must look at the actual neuro-biological mechanisms that developers exploit to hijack our attention.

Body

- I. Main Point #1: There are numerous mechanisms behind how technology companies and software developers intentionally exploit the dopamine systems of our neurobiology, which keep us engaged with their product or provided service.
 - A. Subpoint: One primary method of “dopamine-hijacking” is utilizing it to lock users into an “infinite scroll” (better known to some of you as the “doom scroll”) so that their product becomes your primary focus, and you forget all your pressing responsibilities
 - 1. Sub-Subpoint: Software engineers utilize "infinite scroll" to remove natural stopping points, keeping users in a state of constant consumption.
 - 2. Sub-Subpoint: This design choice prevents the brain from processing the "completion" of a task, leading to the "brain fry" many of us feel.
 - B. Subpoint: Another primary method of dopamine-hijacking is the use of variable-ratio reinforcement.
 - 1. Sub-Subpoint: According to research by Montag et al. (2019), these features are specifically designed to trigger a physiological addiction response rather than a choice.
 - 2. Sub-Subpoint: This tactic targets internal reward circuits, making the "addiction" a result of intentional engineering.
 - C. Subpoint: Dopamine-hijacking’s impact on student well-being.
 - 1. Sub-Subpoint: This exploitation leads to significant sleep problems and academic struggles for students in our generation (Center for Humane Technology, 2023).
 - 2. Sub-Subpoint: My fellow classmates are essentially the "victims" of these strategies, facing daily battles with their own focus.

Transition Sentence: (signal to the audience you have finished Main Point #1; introduce Main Point #2): While many believe they can simply "turn it off," the biology of the brain proves that personal responsibility is not a fair fight against intentional, exploitative engineering.

- II. Main Point #2: We must shift from "self-control" to policy-based solutions
 - A. Subpoint: We must address the counterargument that distraction is merely a "failure of willpower."
 - 1. Sub-Subpoint: A common belief is that distraction is a personal failure, but neuroimaging evidence shows that these apps actually suppress the prefrontal cortex (Lorenz, R. C., et al. (2015)).
 - 2. Sub-Subpoint: Because this area of the brain is required for executive function, users are biologically disadvantaged when trying to resist.
 - B. Subpoint: Benefits and procedure for implementing neuro-ethical design standards.

**Outline should be written in complete sentences.*

***Remember to incorporate all 5 sources into paper. Try your best to cite articles in a natural manner that fits the flow of the paper.*

****Highlight sentences with citations.*

*****Number of subpoints and sub-subpoints may vary. Just remember that if you have an A, you must have at least a B. If you have a 1, you must have at least a 2.*

1. Sub-Subpoint: We must support legislative policies, like the SMART Act, to limit exploitative features used in software engineering (SMART Act, S.2314, 116th Cong. (2019)).
 2. Sub-Subpoint: This act aims to ban the very features, such as auto-play and infinite scroll, that create the dopamine loops we've discussed.
- C. Subpoint: Shifting the burden of responsibility from the individual onto the policy-makers and developers
1. Sub-Subpoint: My goal is to pursue a career where I serve people and protect their health; this starts with advocating for neuro-ethics (Bhargava, V. R., & Velasquez, M. (2021)).
 2. Sub-Subpoint: Policy restores cognitive autonomy by ensuring companies can no longer operate outside the confines of law.

Transition Sentence: (signal to the audience you have finished Main Point #2; introduce Main Point #3): Once we have protective policies in place, we can visualize a healthier relationship with our devices.

III. Main Point #3: What life looks like when we reclaim our cognitive autonomy.

- A. Subpoint: Imagine what life could be like with you back in the "driver's seat."
1. Sub-Subpoint: Imagine the mental clarity you would gain by being in complete control of your own mind and actions.
 2. Sub-Subpoint: This clarity allows for greater academic success and more meaningful professional relationships.
- B. Subpoint: Let's hear an inspiring transformation story from somebody who has reformed their technology use.
1. Sub-Subpoint: Consider a student who, after breaking free from these dopamine loops, regained their focus and peace of mind.
 2. Sub-Subpoint: This transformation shows that we deserve to be in control of our own cognitive health.
- C. Subpoint: Cognitive autonomy will help protect your future careers and well-being.
1. Sub-Subpoint: As future professionals, we must ensure our focus is preserved to be successful in our chosen fields.
 2. Sub-Subpoint: Reclaiming our autonomy means technology becomes a tool we use, rather than a system that uses us.

Transitional Phrase: (signal to audience you have finished all main points and will now conclude the speech): We have analyzed the science and visualized a healthier "online" future; now let's review what we've discussed and let's really emphasize what it is that we all need to do to resolve this issue.

Conclusion

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- I. **Summary:** (Restate goal and main points): We have examined the science of exploitation, why willpower is insufficient against engineering, and how the SMART Act can restore our autonomy. You can take action yourself by supporting neuro-ethical legislation and advocating for more standards that protect our collective cognitive health. Give your local congressmen a call, they'll never make a change if they don't know the extent of this issues negative affects.
- II. **Memorable Close:** (Provide closure and leave a lasting impression): To conclude, I want to leave you with a comparison: casinos are designed to turn off executive-functioning regions of your brain through the intentional lack of windows and clocks to keep you gambling. Technology should be a tool that we pick up and put down, not a casino with no clocks. We must not let ourselves become enslaved by it, forgetting our responsibilities...forgetting ourselves. Let's all advocate for a world where the exit door is easy to find and reclaim control over our lives!

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References

- Bhargava, V. R., & Velasquez, M. (2021). Ethics of the Attention Economy: The Problem of Social Media Addiction. *Business Ethics Quarterly*, 31(3), 321-359.
- Center for Humane Technology. (2023). Ledger of Harms: Dopamine and the Brain.
- Lorenz, R. C., et al. (2015). Video game training and the prefrontal cortex. *Molecular Psychiatry*, 20, 34–39.
- Montag, C., Lachmann, B., Herrlich, M., & Zweig, K. (2019). Addictive features of social media/messenger platforms and free-to-play games: A design perspective from psychology and informatics. *International Journal of Environmental Research and Public Health*, 16(14), 2612.
- Social Media Addiction Reduction Technology (SMART) Act, S.2314, 116th Cong. (2019).

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